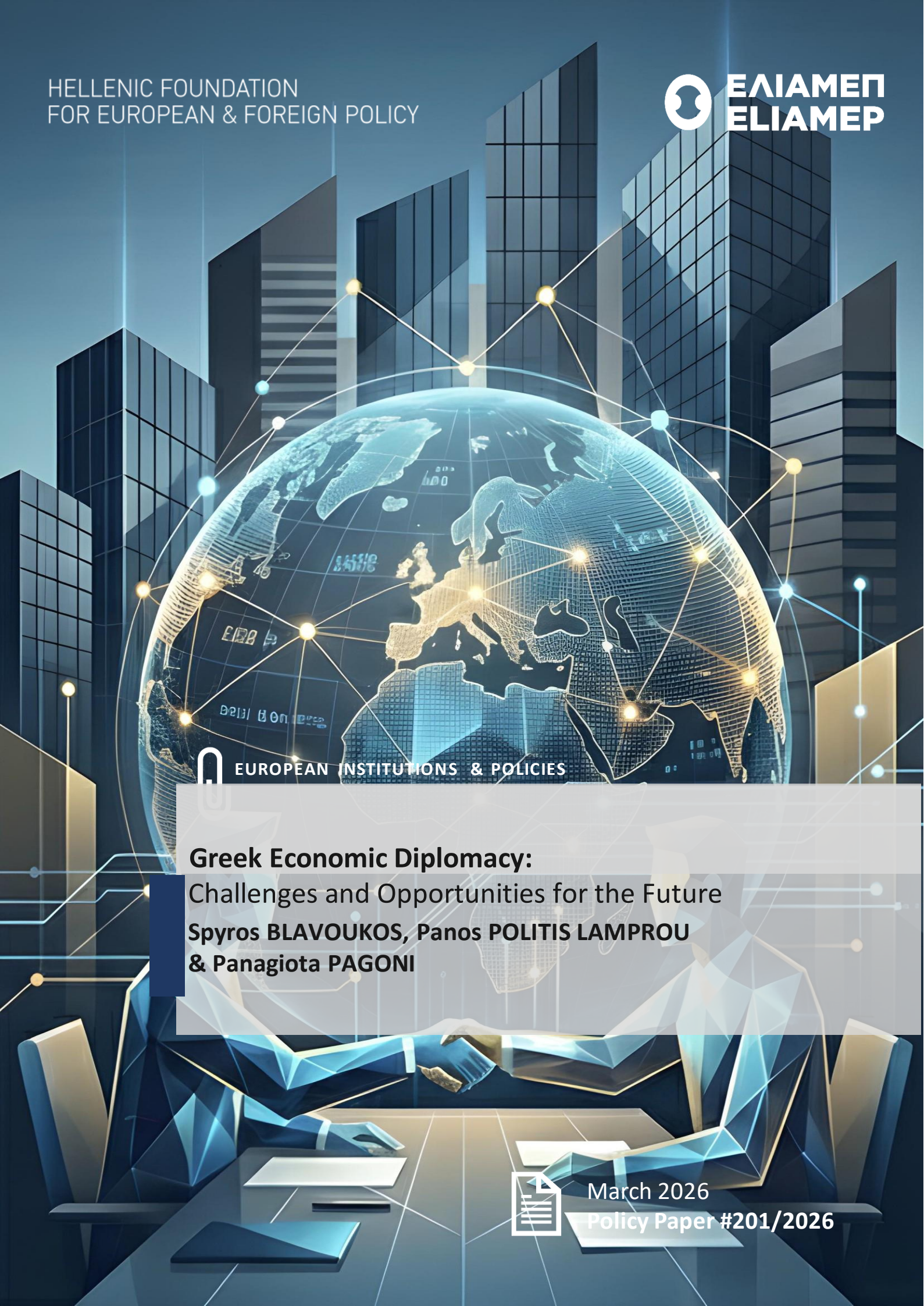
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Greek Economic Diplomacy:
Challenges and Opportunities for the Future

Spyros BLAVOUKOS, Panos POLITIS LAMPROU & Panagiota PAGONI

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Cover image: *Generated with the use of artificial intelligence.*

Summary

- In the contemporary environment, economic diplomacy encompasses four key dimensions: (a) trade/investment diplomacy, (b) the diplomacy of international rules and agreements, (c) development cooperation, and (d) economic security diplomacy.
- In Greece, the system of economic diplomacy is organised around the General Secretariat of International Economic Relations and Openness of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. At the same time, other ministries and government services also play an important role, creating a complex institutional ecosystem in which coordination is necessary in order to enhance the effectiveness and efficiency of the relevant actions.
- Although the importance of economic diplomacy is recognised and relevant initiatives have been undertaken in the right direction, both at the level of organisation and at the level of actions, the main challenges that Greek economic diplomacy continues to face are: (a) the absence of a holistic approach and strategy, (b) the tackling of bureaucracy and business barriers, (c) limited resources, and (d) insufficient recognition of its value.
- International practices, such as the Team Finland network, the French model of special representatives for economic diplomacy, as well as the national strategies of the Netherlands and the United Kingdom for the creation of a national economic identity, constitute some good practices followed in Europe and may, under certain conditions and with appropriate adjustments, inform relevant Greek initiatives.
    - The policy recommendations are structured on the basis of three categories:
    - Structure and organisation:
        - Strengthening Enterprise Greece,
        - Reorganisation of the recruitment and training system for officials of the Offices of Economic and Commercial Affairs (OEY).
    - Operations and adaptability:
        - Enhancing relations with local and sectoral chambers of commerce,
        - Establishing a formal consultation mechanism for direct interaction with the “users” of economic diplomacy,
        - Modernising procedures, following a detailed mapping of the needs and obstacles faced by the stakeholders involved,
        - Providing tailored services by Offices of Economic and Commercial Affairs based on the size, and therefore the needs, of businesses,
        - Better utilising the Greek diaspora and Greek communities abroad.
    - Formulation of a strategy for economic diplomacy:
        - National dimension:
            - Creation of a National Strategy for Economic Diplomacy with a horizon beyond 2030, with a central role given to the geoeconomic dimensions of economic diplomacy,
            - Raising the visibility of a unified Greek “brand name”.

- European Dimension:
  - Promoting the idea of establishing a European Export Credit Agency, while recognising the relevant reservations expressed by our partners in the EU - the Greek Presidency of the Council of Ministers in 2027 could provide an opportunity to further explore this idea,
  - Achieving a positive "pillar assessment", in order for Greek institutions to become eligible for the financing of actions in third countries,
  - Promoting and implementing, particularly during the Greek Presidency of the Council of the EU in 2027, measures aimed at completing the Single Market, on the basis of the Draghi and Letta reports,
  - Increasing the number of Greeks serving in key positions in European institutions, as well as hosting new European agencies in cities across Greece.

Introduction

In today's era, economic diplomacy constitutes an integral and strategically embedded component of every state's foreign policy. The increasingly intense geopolitical and geoeconomic competition, combined with the growing economic interdependence between states and regions, highlight its importance as a key instrument for shaping international relations and exercising influence. In this context, economic diplomacy contributes decisively not only to the promotion of national economic interests, such as strengthening trade, investment and extroversion, but also to the advancement of broader strategic, political and geoeconomic objectives. As such, it becomes essential for strengthening a state's international presence and for its active participation in shaping global policies and the evolution of the international economic landscape.

Given the great importance of economic diplomacy, this policy paper aims to highlight the challenges and systemic weaknesses faced by Greek economic diplomacy and to propose tangible solutions for improving its effectiveness as well as for its modernisation. Many of the concerns, as well as the proposals presented in this paper, are the outcome of two closed-door discussions that took place at the premises of ELIAMEP in February and April 2025. More specifically, the first closed-door discussion enabled an exchange of views between representatives of organisations from the broader public sector and business associations. The second focused on dialogue among representatives of private companies, associations and chambers of commerce of different sizes and sectors of activity. In this way, it became possible to draw holistic conclusions regarding the state of Greek economic diplomacy. [1]

The policy paper is structured into five sections. The first section presents the theoretical conceptualisation of economic diplomacy and aims to provide a brief description of its different dimensions and of the current academic debate surrounding its multidimensional nature. The second analyses briefly the Greek institutional framework for the design and implementation of economic diplomacy. The third section highlights the main weaknesses and problems affecting Greek economic diplomacy. The fourth section presents a number of illustrative examples of good practices applied at the international level that could serve as a basis and inspiration for innovative actions and policies. Finally, the fifth section brings together a series of policy recommendations, which are classified into three categories: (a) structure and organisation, (b) operations and adaptability, and (c) the formulation of a strategy for Greek economic diplomacy.

[1] The authors would like to thank Ms Vicky Makrygianni, Director of the International Relations Division at SEV, and Mr Panagiotis Papanastasiou, Minister Counsellor for Economic and Commercial Affairs A' at the Permanent Representation of Greece to the EU, for their participation in the discussion and the valuable insights they shared during the preparation of this paper.

Economic Diplomacy: Content and Dimensions

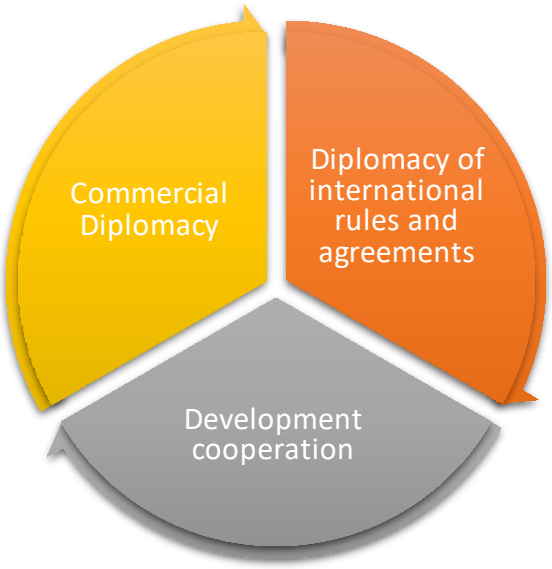
Conceptualisation

Economic diplomacy lies at the intersection of international relations, economics, international political economy and diplomacy. However, there is considerable confusion regarding its precise definition and what it encompasses. In general terms, economic diplomacy refers to the use of the state apparatus both for the formulation of international economic policy and for supporting the internationalisation of national businesses (Chohan, 2021). This definition incorporates both the multilateral and the bilateral dimensions of economic diplomacy (Cavalcanti Muniz, 2023, p. 18). Another interesting approach is contained in the definition provided by Okano-Heijmans (2011), according to which *"Economic diplomacy is understood as the use of political means as leverage in international negotiations, with the aim of enhancing national economic prosperity, and the use of economic leverage to increase the political stability of the nation."* This definition is closer to contemporary debates on international competitiveness, strategic autonomy in critical sectors, and economic security in the face of international threats.

Within a strictly theoretical and analytical framework, globalisation, as well as the evolving fragmentation of the global economic system, have contributed to the redefinition of economic diplomacy, broadening its scope to include three main and complementary dimensions (Okano-Heijmans 2016, pp. 552–554):

1. the promotion of trade and investment at the general or sectoral/company level (commercial diplomacy at the government-to-society level/G2S),
2. negotiations between two or more countries that facilitate economic transactions or trade and/or investment agreements (the diplomacy of international rules and agreements at the government-to-government level - G2G), and
3. efforts to exert influence through mutually beneficial cooperation for developmental or economic purposes with broader political objectives (development cooperation diplomacy).

Figure I: The trinity of economic diplomacy

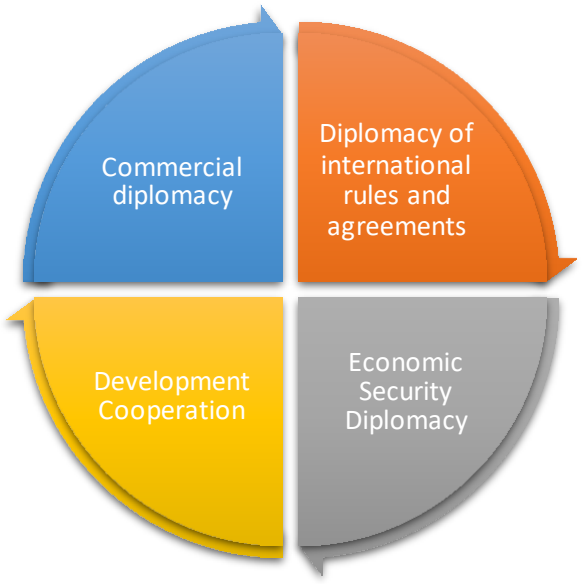


Source: Okano-Heijmans (2016, . 556).

However, in light of geoeconomic competition, the return of Realpolitik to the international stage, and the growing salience of issues related to economic security, a fourth dimension is increasingly emerging. This dimension encompasses the "diplomacy of economic security" and relates to efforts by a state to exercise unilateral influence through measures of economic coercion, trade defence, sanctions, or other instruments aimed at advancing strategic interests in terms of power. This additional dimension reflects the intensifying tendency to instrumentalise the economy for geopolitical purposes, highlighting a shift from a normative and cooperative framework towards a more competitive and conflictual system of international relations, in which the concept of power and the imposition of the law of the strongest once again assume a dominant role. Woolcock (2025) also emphasises the importance of the economic dimension of states' foreign policy, identifying within the definition of economic diplomacy distinct components such as the strategic dimension of projecting state power ("economic statecraft")[2] and economic sanctions.

[2] For example, in the case of China, the strategic dimension lies in promoting its national industry abroad in order to consolidate its geopolitical dominance in critical sectors (Xiaotong, 2025).

Figure II: The quadrangle of economic diplomacy



Therefore, in the contemporary international environment, a clear repositioning of economic diplomacy as a central pillar of states' foreign policy is taking place. Although the above dimensions constitute a unified system of economic diplomacy, they nevertheless represent distinct - albeit largely overlapping - forms of diplomatic action, each with a different scope of application and set of objectives (Okano-Heijmans, 2016, p. 553).

The Four Dimensions of Economic Diplomacy

Commercial/Investment Diplomacy

This constitutes the most extensively studied form of economic diplomacy. It focuses on the promotion of trade and investment, both at a general level (e.g. national export strategies) and through targeted actions aimed at supporting businesses or specific sectors through state initiatives. Saner and Yiu (2003) define it as the activities carried out by diplomats and government actors with the aim of strengthening international business activity and national competitiveness. According to Woolcock (2025), commercial diplomacy consists in promoting national business interests in targeted foreign markets through, among other things, the provision of information, the organisation of trade fairs, and the resolution of disputes between exporters and the governments of third countries.

Table I: Definition of Commercial Diplomacy

"Commercial diplomacy describes the work of diplomatic missions in support of the home country's business and finance sectors in their pursuit of economic success and the country's general objective of national development. It includes the promotion of inward and outward investment as well as trade. Important aspects of a commercial diplomats' work is the supplying of information about export and investment opportunities and organising and helping to act as hosts to trade missions from home. In some cases, commercial diplomats could also promote economic ties through advising and support of both domestic and foreign companies for investment decisions.
Source: Saner and Yiu (2003, p. 12)

Diplomacy of International Rules and Agreements

This refers to interstate negotiations and policy strategies aimed at shaping frameworks that facilitate international trade and investment through free trade agreements, regional initiatives, international organisations, multilateral negotiations, and institutional arrangements. Unlike commercial/investment diplomacy, which focuses on the day-to-day support provided to businesses by diplomatic missions and on the practical promotion of exports and investment, the Diplomacy of International Rules and Agreements concerns primarily the political level of rule-making and alliance-building. Particularly since the 1990s, a gradual shift has been observed from multilateral trade negotiations towards bilateral and regional agreements, a development that has been accompanied by the increasing "politicisation" of trade policy. Negotiations now involve not only economic issues—such as market access—but also geopolitical objectives and incentives, including, among others, the projection of influence and the strengthening of strategic partnerships (Okano-Heijmans, 2016, p. 557).

In pursuing their objectives, states may make use of both national and international channels. The former mainly concern the promotion of trade relations through bilateral contacts, while the latter relate to interactions within multilateral frameworks, such as international and/or regional organisations, including the World Trade Organization (WTO), the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD), and other organisations involved in economic cooperation and the financing of development initiatives.

For EU member states, as well as for states participating in other regional formations of economic and trade cooperation with varying degrees of scale and intensity (such as MERCOSUR and ASEAN), a regional option also exists. Under this approach, each member state seeks to promote its national priorities in shaping the positions of these groupings in international trade negotiations.[3] In the case of the European Union in particular, the negotiation of trade agreements with third countries falls under the Common Commercial Policy, which is an exclusive competence of the European Union (Article 3, Treaty on the Functioning of the European Union). This leaves national governments with limited room for manoeuvre. In practice, this means that EU member state governments must act in a timely manner to ensure that their specific priorities in these areas become part of the European positions in negotiations with third actors, whether these are states or other regional organisations. Before any EU trade agreement is signed, extensive deliberations take place within the relevant institutional bodies, where each member state

actively promotes its positions and interests. As a result, a multi-level negotiation process emerges, involving both the European and the international levels of policy-making in a continuous and dynamic interaction. According to data from the Council of the European Union (2024), the European Union has concluded more than 40 trade agreements with over 70 countries and/or regions.

Development Cooperation

Development cooperation represents a form of economic diplomacy that can be expressed through two distinct, though not mutually exclusive, approaches, depending on the perspective and objectives of the donor state. The first approach aims to promote political goals such as good governance, democracy, and human rights. In the second approach, cooperation takes the form of economic assistance, including the strengthening of trade relations, the attraction of investment, and the promotion of economic development. In order to emphasise the element of mutual benefit, this approach is often referred to as "economic cooperation" rather than "development aid" (Okano-Heijmans, 2016, p. 556). In addition, it should be noted that there are two forms of development aid: (a) tied aid, which involves a commitment by the recipient to purchase goods and services from suppliers located in the donor country; and (b) untied aid, which does not restrict the recipient with regard to the origin of the goods and services.

Economic Security Diplomacy

Recognising the growing risks arising from changes in the broader geopolitical and geoeconomic environment, the European Union has developed an Economic Security Strategy, within which it has identified four categories of risks that must be addressed as a matter of priority. These risks are associated with:

1. the resilience of supply chains,
2. the physical security and cybersecurity of critical infrastructure,
3. technological security and the risk of technology leakage, and
4. the instrumentalisation (or weaponisation) of economic dependencies or economic coercion

[3] For example, France has expressed reservations regarding the free trade agreement with the MERCOSUR countries, putting forward arguments related to unfair competition and the environmental standards that must apply to products entering the European market (Reuters, 2025).

The spirit and objectives of this strategy are also reflected in various other thematic initiatives of the European Union, including the Critical Raw Materials Act, which identifies critical raw materials as essential for achieving the green transition. More specifically, this act highlights the high risk of disruptions in the supply of critical raw materials and sets specific targets aimed at strengthening European self-sufficiency, including, among other things, minimum benchmarks for extraction, processing, and recycling within the EU. The importance of supply security is also explicitly reiterated in the European Chips Act.

Additional Dimensions of Economic Diplomacy

Economic diplomacy also extends to other equally important thematic areas that reflect its continuously evolving nature and point to a more holistic approach to its conceptualisation. These are aspects that often function in a complementary manner, shaping a multidimensional field of action for states. **Energy diplomacy** constitutes a characteristic example closely intertwined with issues of economic diplomacy, particularly in light of the ongoing and intensifying instrumentalisation of energy dependencies (Griffiths, 2019). In the same context, **international corridors** have increasingly become inseparable from the contemporary practice of economic diplomacy by states. One of the most significant initiatives in this regard, which also directly concerns Greece, is the India–Middle East–Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC). This initiative aims to connect the three geographical regions through energy, trade, and technological linkages, while also seeking to counterbalance the growing influence of China's "Belt and Road Initiative" (Sacks, 2023). Finally, **science diplomacy** refers to international cooperation in the fields of science and technology aimed at addressing common challenges, such as pandemics. According to Copeland (2016), it constitutes a useful instrument of foreign policy that is often overlooked by states. It operates in a complementary manner to economic diplomacy, as it strengthens international stability and innovation through peaceful scientific cooperation. However, science itself may also be instrumentalised to advance national interests and maintain (or regain) power, thereby further intensifying geopolitical tensions and geoeconomic competition (Fägersten, 2022).

A key instrument of foreign policy in general, closely linked to economic interactions, is sanctions. States use them as a means of achieving political objectives (Ronzitti, 2016). According to Mulder (2022), sanctions first emerged in the early twentieth century[4] and, while they function as a (peaceful) alternative to war, they largely rely on wartime tactics and may have serious consequences. Sanctions can take various forms, including the suspension of development aid, the freezing of transactions, embargoes, or quota, and are based on the existence of an asymmetric relationship of dependence between states (Cika & Veshi, 2024).

[4] For a detailed presentation of the economic sanctions imposed between 1914 and 2000 in order to achieve foreign policy objectives, see Hufbauer et al. (2007).

At the level of the European Union in particular, sanctions (or restrictive measures) constitute one of the main instruments of the Common Foreign and Security Policy (CFSP) (Portela, 2010). Although they have been applied since the 1980s, the EU's stance began to become more assertive from 2010 onwards (see sanctions against Iran, Côte d'Ivoire, Syria, and Russia), with member states accepting that sanctions (a) must be effective, (b) must entail a real cost, and (c) may affect individuals and/or businesses not directly related to the measures (Portela, 2016). Since 2022, sanctions have become one of the principal instruments of response to Russia's war of aggression against Ukraine[5], alongside the provision of various forms of support to the Ukrainian resistance. The effectiveness of European sanctions against third actors is often questioned by experts.[6]

Greece is systematically active in this field of economic diplomacy, mainly through the European Union. For example, it implements the EU sanctions imposed on Russia in response to the war in Ukraine and recently adopted Law 5202/2025, which establishes a national mechanism for the screening of foreign direct investments in sectors related to national security or public order, thereby incorporating the relevant European regulation into Greek legislation.

[5] By September 2025, the European Union had adopted 19 sanctions packages against Russia, aiming to exert economic pressure so that the Russian economy would not be able to finance and sustain the war against Ukraine.

[6] Giumelli (2013) has developed one of the most widely used analytical frameworks for assessing the success (or failure) of sanctions. This framework includes four key questions concerning:
(a) the relative importance of sanctions within the broader foreign policy strategy toward the third country;
(b) the underlying logic of sanctions (coercion, constraint, or signalling);
(c) the comparison between the unintended and the expected outcomes of sanctions; and
(d) the existence (or absence) of alternative foreign policy instruments that might have been more effective in the case under examination.

The Greek System of Economic Diplomacy

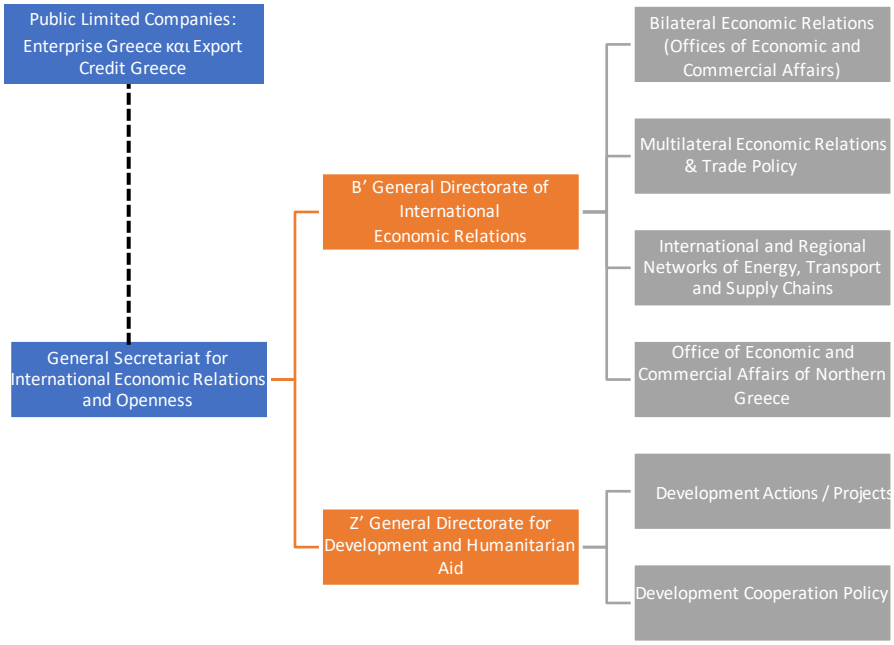
The Greek system of economic diplomacy is active across a broad range of policies and actions, implemented primarily by the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. The main administrative structure responsible for Greek economic diplomacy is the General Secretariat for International Economic Relations and Openness (GS-IERO), which operates within the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and falls under the authority of the Deputy Minister responsible for Economic Diplomacy. This Secretariat is responsible for bilateral and multilateral economic relations, commercial diplomacy, energy diplomacy, as well as international development cooperation policy. At the same time, it supervises two key specialised organisations: Enterprise Greece and Export Credit Greece. Enterprise Greece aims to promote Greece as an international business and export hub by highlighting and supporting significant investment opportunities, as well as by promoting the country's high-quality exportable products and services to the international business community (Enterprise Greece, 2025). Export Credit Greece, re-established in 2022 as the Hellenic Export Credit Agency, serves as the state export credit institution, with the primary mission of supporting Greek companies engaged in international transactions or investments by providing export credit insurance, guarantees, and financing (Export Credit Greece, 2025). More specifically, following its re-establishment, the now public limited company has expanded the scope of its activities to include advisory services for (potential) exporting firms and broader product portfolios. Both of the above organisations, which are of central importance for Greek economic diplomacy, are entering a more modernised operational framework through reforms provided for in the National Strategy for Extroversion, approved by the Government Council for Economic Policy in September 2025.

However, the current institutional ecosystem of economic diplomacy in Greece is not limited solely to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. Other actors involved in the design and/or implementation of relevant policies include, among others:

- the Prime Minister's Economic Office, which plays a central role in coordinating strategic directions and actions;
- the Ministry of National Economy and Finance, responsible for macroeconomic and fiscal policies that affect the business environment;
- the Ministry of Development, which is actively involved in designing policies on competitiveness, innovation, business support, and investment attraction;
- the Ministry of Migration and Asylum, which is responsible for the process of issuing permanent residence permits for investors (golden visa).

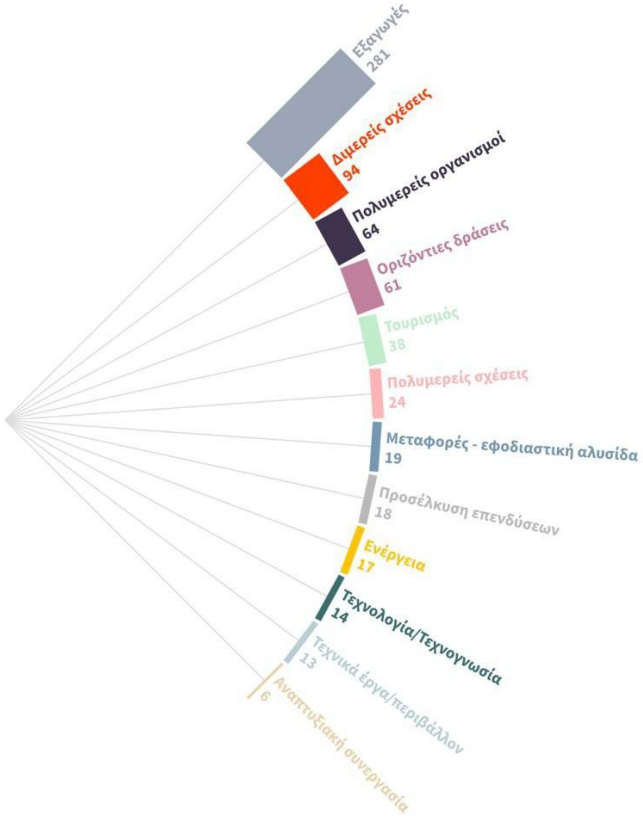
According to Lee and Hocking (2010), coordination among all the actors involved is key to promoting the country's economic and commercial outward orientation. In line with the concept of the "national diplomatic system" (Hocking, 2007), the Greek Ministry of Foreign Affairs acts as the "integrator" or "coordinator" of economic diplomacy, cooperating with other government agencies, the private sector, and civil society groups.

Figure III: Basic Structure for the Design and Implementation of Greek Economic Diplomacy



The Strategic Plan of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs for 2022–2025 identifies the strengthening of outward orientation as one of its five main strategic pillars. In particular, it refers to ten objectives that must be achieved, which include, among others, attracting investment, strengthening exports, and enhancing the presence of Greek companies in international technical and environmental projects. At the same time, the annual National Strategic Plans for Extroversion (NSPE) provide direction, specify priorities, and offer operational guidance for achieving the aforementioned objectives. For example, the NSPE 2025 presents a total of 649 concrete actions, classified into 10 categories, which concern target countries, multilateral organisations, and horizontal initiatives (see Figure III). Among these, the number of actions concerning the United States of America (48), Italy (31), and Germany (28) stands out, countries of longstanding economic importance for Greece.

Figure IV: Number of Actions by Action Category (NSPE 2025)



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Challenges for Greek Economic Diplomacy

Greek economic diplomacy faces a number of challenges that need to be addressed in order to fully leverage its potential at the global level. Despite the recognition of the need for modernisation and reforms, and the related initiatives that have been undertaken, several issues continue to be identified that affect the effectiveness of its mechanisms.

Absence of a Holistic Approach and Strategy

A strategic approach is a necessary prerequisite for promoting a coherent and long-term policy of economic outward orientation. Within this framework, and given that available resources are limited, there is a need to prioritise different international markets in order to design and implement multiannual Action Plans for specific markets.

Although economic diplomacy primarily and formally falls under the responsibility of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, it constitutes a policy field that requires institutional communication and interaction among different public bodies and services. For example, successful economic diplomacy cannot exist without the development of close relations and effective cooperation between ministries such as the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Ministry of Development and Investments, and the Ministry of National Economy and Finance. At the same time, there is a proliferation of different bodies, which in many cases may overlap, creating increasingly complex procedures and exacerbating potential delays (see Chapter 3).

The lack of a unified and well-organised approach perpetuates the absence of institutional communication, intensifies existing problems, and partly neutralises the substantive efforts made both by the institutions involved and by individual officials.

Combating Bureaucracy and Business Obstacles

The broader rigidity of the public sector and of bodies supervised by the general government, although it tends to be mitigated through the design and implementation of targeted policies, reduces the effectiveness of the initiatives implemented and delays processes that are critical for investors. For example, Elevate Greece, an initiative that offers the possibility of granting residence permits to individuals who invest at least €250,000 in start-ups registered in the National Registry of Start-ups, requires the issuance of appropriate legislative provisions and/or circulars by other competent ministries as well, such as the Ministry of Migration and Asylum. Within the same context, foreign companies face considerable risks and incur significant costs when seeking to invest in Greece. (e.g. cooperation with law firms is often required in order to address issues related to contracts and the complexities of the Greek legal system.).

Table III: Bureaucracy Without Borders: The European Dimension

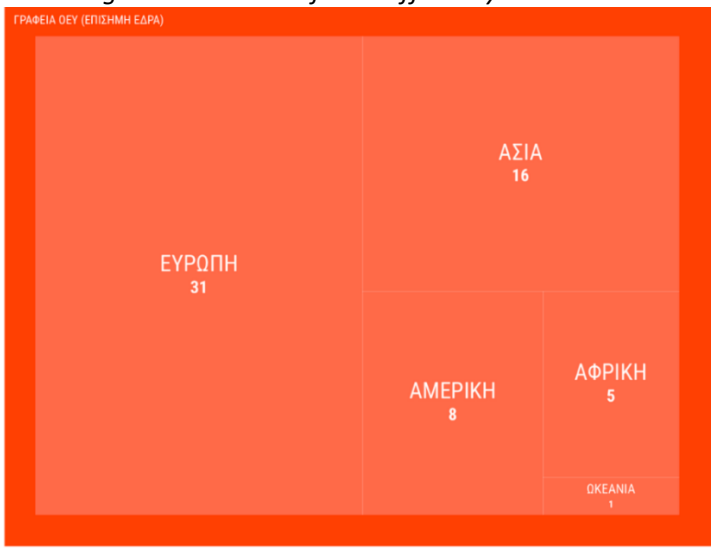
In a recent publication by BusinessEurope, the federation of industrial and business associations in the European Union, the need for a drastic reduction of the regulatory "burden" at the European level is emphasised, with explicit reference to excessive bureaucracy and the obstacles faced by cross-border business activities. In another report, BusinessEurope notes that more than 60% of European companies consider the regulatory framework to be an obstacle to investment, while more than half of small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) view regulatory barriers and administrative "burdens" as the greatest challenge they face.

The need to simplify procedures and significantly reduce bureaucracy is highlighted in two reports that are considered milestones for the future of the European project: the Letta Report and the Draghi Report. In the latter, it is stressed that the excessive regulatory and administrative burden negatively affects the competitiveness of European companies. It is also noted that the opportunity cost of the absence of a harmonised European regulatory framework amounts to €200 billion per year. Recognising the importance of addressing procedural complexity, the European Commission's Work Programme for 2025 includes 11 legislative initiatives aimed at simplifying numerous procedures and legislative frameworks. Similarly, the Work Programme for 2026 contains 20 new initiatives related to the simplification of procedures.

Limited Resources

It is a widely acknowledged fact that there is a serious shortage of human resources serving in the Offices of Economic and Commercial Affairs (OEY).[7] At the same time, the relatively small number of 60 OEY offices worldwide (excluding the Permanent Representation of Greece to the EU, which appears on the official website of the competent General Secretariat but, of course, has a far more complex and expanded role) hinders the international outreach of Greek businesses and limits the potential of Greece's economic and commercial interests abroad. During the period 2015–2025, 66 positions for OEY officers were announced for admission to the National School of Public Administration and Local Government. Given the number of retirements, the staffing needs of the Central Service for OEY officers[8], as well as the requirements for staffing the 61 offices abroad (see Figure IV), the limited number of announced positions indicates the absence of a sufficient number of personnel for the planning and implementation of the country's economic diplomacy. At the same time, however, diplomatic missions are being established that cannot be adequately staffed and are therefore unable to effectively carry out their multidimensional mandate. According to a recent yearbook of the OEY service, there are currently 172 active OEY officers (20 Minister-Counsellors, 78 First- and Second-Class Counsellors, and 74 First-, Second-, and Third-Class Secretaries).

Figure V: Number of OEY Offices by Continent



Created with Flourish.studio. The Permanent Representation to the EU is included. Russia and Turkey are counted as part of Europe.

[7] The human resources also include locally employed staff, who reside in the country where the offices operate and usually speak the local language. Their contribution is of critical importance, as they possess extensive knowledge of the needs and challenges of the local market and are therefore able to make a significant contribution.

[8] In addition to the need to place OEY officers in the Diplomatic Office of the competent Deputy Minister and the General Secretariat, the Central Service includes the B' General Directorate for International Economic Relations and the Z' General Directorate for Development and Humanitarian Assistance, with 7 and 3 directorates respectively, employing a significant number of OEY officers. At the same time, there are other (General) Directorates (e.g., Directorate G2) or offices (e.g., the Office of Economic and Commercial Affairs of Northern Greece) where the utilisation of officers from this service branch is considered particularly valuable.

It is also necessary to ensure the strategically guided allocation of available resources in order to finance targeted interventions and programmes that contribute to strengthening the international outreach of the economy. In this direction, the optimal utilisation of available national and EU resources is required in order to support the development and growth of business entrepreneurship.

Insufficient Recognition of the Value of Economic Diplomacy

Traditional or "political" diplomacy concerns the officials of the Diplomatic Staff of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, who remain the primary actors of Greek foreign policy. They manage issues that often fall within the realm of "high politics" and, depending on their rank, assume leadership of diplomatic and consular missions abroad. In the past, and due to the numerous structural and organisational changes affecting the Economic and Commercial Affairs (ECA) corps (Tsardanidis, 2018), there was a widespread perception that economic diplomacy was neither an integral component nor a priority of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. As a result, the work of ECA officials was often relegated to a secondary role. Although this trend is gradually changing through tangible measures promoted by both the political and administrative leadership, additional emphasis must be placed on highlighting the importance and contribution of economic diplomacy to the achievement of broader objectives and strategic priorities of Greek foreign policy.

Furthermore, given the aforementioned shortage of personnel and the limited number of ECA offices abroad, members of the Diplomatic Staff are often required to perform a wide range of duties, including the promotion of Greek economic interests. However, diplomats—particularly those from earlier cohorts—have received limited training in matters of economic and commercial diplomacy, which complicates the execution of their diverse responsibilities, especially in missions with limited staff. Nevertheless, it should be acknowledged that the Greek Ministry of Foreign Affairs has taken steps to improve the level of expertise provided in economic and commercial matters (such as investment promotion), as indicated by Presidential Decree No. 2/2016 (and its earlier version).

At the same time, cooperation and relations between officials of the ECA corps and members of the Diplomatic Staff of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs have not always been harmonious. Although the situation has improved significantly with newer cohorts of officials from both corps, internal frictions and earlier perceptions regarding hierarchy and institutional roles have created tensions, affecting the overall effectiveness of economic diplomacy. Smooth coexistence and constructive cooperation between the two corps constitute a prerequisite for effectively promoting Greek interests abroad.

Expansion into regions without a Greek presence

While the country's economic diplomacy has produced tangible results in regions where there is a strong Greek presence, primarily by leveraging that presence and relying on the Greek diaspora, less successful engagement can be observed in regions where the Greek presence is limited. Stimulating interest in Greek products or investments in these areas constitutes an important challenge, as these are emerging economies that may represent a window of opportunity for exports, investments, as well as additional forms of economic and commercial cooperation.

Good practices in Europe

Each country adopts and shapes its own model for the design and implementation of economic diplomacy on the basis of its institutional particularities, strategic priorities, and the structure of its public administration. Having examined the models of different countries, we focus on three of them that are of particular interest and offer added value for the Greek case. The Appendix presents additional noteworthy ideas from other systems—some of them outside Europe—in order to provide a more comprehensive perspective. The search for best practices is, of course, not exhausted by our research, but should remain continuous and regularly updated.

Finland: Team Finland

Team Finland constitutes an integrated cooperation network that coordinates the efforts of various Finnish public bodies and organisations to promote the country's economic interests abroad. The network includes the Ministry of Economic Affairs and Employment, the Ministry for Foreign Affairs, and the Ministry of Education and Culture, as well as relevant financing organisations (e.g. Business Finland, Finnvera, Tesi), funds, cultural institutions and academic institutes. At the same time, the network is represented abroad through more than 80 teams, which provide services tailored to the specific characteristics of local markets. The added value of this initiative lies in the integration and coordination of all services offered to businesses, creating a coherent service chain (e.g. business advisory services, financing). In this way, companies gain access to services that address their internationalisation needs, while efforts are also made to remove barriers to trade and to attract foreign investment into the country.

As a practice of economic diplomacy, Team Finland is considered a successful initiative, particularly for small and medium-sized enterprises and mid-cap companies (ETLA, 2022). Export promotion services are particularly useful for smaller firms that lack the capital and networks necessary to internationalise through their own resources. Furthermore, recognising the close relationship between trade and politics and taking into account limited resources, Finland proceeded in 2024 to integrate all international activities of Business Finland[9] into the Ministry for Foreign Affairs.

[9] Business Finland is the Finnish government organisation tasked with guiding and supporting companies in identifying opportunities in future markets. At the same time, it provides funding for research, development and innovation activities. Between 2010 and 2024, annual funding exceeded €400 million, while in 2020 it reached €1.74 billion (Business Finland, 2025).

France: Special representatives for economic diplomacy

In 2012, the Quai d'Orsay launched a new initiative: the appointment of Special Representatives for Economic Diplomacy. Although the position is unpaid, the special representatives are assigned a geographical area of responsibility (e.g. a specific country or group of countries) and work to mobilise public and private actors in order to strengthen France's economic, commercial, scientific and cultural relations with the country or region for which they are responsible (Ministère de l'Europe et des Affaires étrangères, 2020). This initiative represents an exemplary public-private partnership, as the role is not limited to diplomats or politicians but also includes highly respected figures from leading French companies who inspire confidence (Verheecke, 2023). With a similar objective, the President of the French Republic may appoint Special Envoys for specific issues. For example, in 2023 President Macron appointed the former Chairman and CEO of ENGIE, a group covering the entire energy value chain, as Special Envoy for IMEC (see section 2.2.5). At the same time, the evaluation process for the heads of French diplomatic and consular missions also takes into account the extent to which they promote French economic interests in their country of accreditation.

The Netherlands and the United Kingdom: Building a National Economic Identity

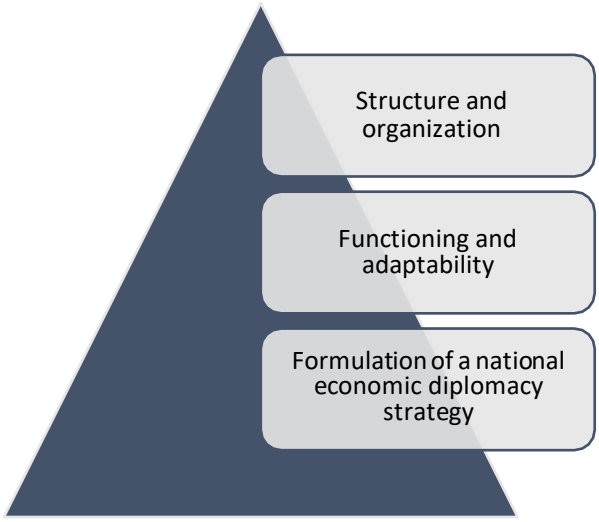
Some countries actively seek to develop an economic nation branding strategy in order to strengthen their exports, attract foreign investment and promote tourism. Unified national brands help link a product or service to its country of origin, thereby providing consumers or end users with greater confidence and assurance. In contrast to countries that promote their national identity primarily in specific sectors, such as tourism (e.g. Greece and the campaign "Live Your Myth in Greece"), the Netherlands adopts a more holistic approach that covers a broader range of policy areas. For example, in 2020 it renewed the logo (The Netherlands Branding) widely used abroad, with the aim of giving new momentum to the promotion of exports, tourism, sport and culture. This strategy is implemented through the country's participation under a unified national identity in international exhibitions, activities of the Dutch diplomatic network and thematic fora. In this way, the Netherlands achieves strong international visibility, enhancing the promotion and competitiveness of its products as well as the favourable business environment it offers.

In 2012, the British government launched the "GREAT Campaign", widely regarded as one of the United Kingdom's most ambitious international promotional initiatives. Its objective was to encourage citizens of third countries to "think" and "feel" differently about the United Kingdom, presenting it as an ideal destination to visit, invest in, trade with and study in (GREAT Campaign, 2021). The initial funding amounted to £113.5 million. Today, however, the campaign also functions as a source of funding for British public bodies, as it has succeeded in securing resources from the private sector. According to data from gov.uk, the campaign has supported more than 1,000 events and initiatives across approximately 200 locations worldwide. According to an estimate by Brand Finance, the "GREAT" brand currently holds a value of £271 million.

Policy Recommendations

The case studies presented above exhibit specific characteristics and features that may not be easily transferable to the Greek context without substantial changes or adjustments. For example, the fragmented allocation of responsibilities and the absence of a stable overarching strategy make it difficult to develop a network similar to Team Finland or to establish an institutional body responsible for managing and promoting a national economic identity. Similarly, the shifting of political priorities at the governmental level exacerbates these challenges, as it prevents the development of a coherent and stable policy that prioritizes the promotion of Greek economic interests across the globe. Nevertheless, there is clearly scope for improvement and for the gradual adaptation of international best practices to the Greek economic diplomacy landscape. In this context, a set of targeted policy interventions is proposed, aimed at strengthening the institutional framework, improving the functioning of the economic diplomacy system, and shaping a national strategy.

Figure VI: Pillars of the Policy Recommendations



1. Structure and Organization:

1.1. **Strenghtening Enterprise Greece**: Enterprise Greece should support the country's export orientation and attract investment. In order to achieve these two objectives, it is necessary to strengthen it (a) in terms of staffing and (b) financially. In addition, Enterprise Greece should not limit its activities solely to strategic or flagship investments, but should also engage with smaller-scale investment projects. Given the limited resources available, it may pursue partnerships with other actors that share similar interests and organize business missions abroad not only with its own resources but also through co-financing from interested private companies or business associations. This requires prior market analysis and the careful selection of international events and trade fairs based on the potential benefits they may generate for Greek economic interests. The impact of such business missions should also be measurable, for example on the basis of the number of agreements concluded, their value, and the quality of the partnerships that emerge.

At the same time, participating businesses should be properly informed in advance so that they have sufficient product availability and a well-organized and efficient supply chain, thereby maximizing the benefits derived from their participation.

1.2. **Reorganization of the recruitment and training system for Officers of Economic and Commercial Affairs (ECA)**

i. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs, and in particular the Diplomatic Academy, should assume a greater role in the recruitment process and initial training of ECA officers, in close cooperation with the National School of Public Administration and Local Government (ESDDA). The ongoing revision of the training programme for Officers of Economic and Commercial Affairs (ECA) at the National School of Public Administration and Local Government (ESDDA) is a step in the right direction. However, the establishment of a hybrid framework of cooperation is considered necessary in order to foster a shared organisational culture and common understanding between members of the Diplomatic Staff and ECA officers. Both diplomats and ECA officers should attend certain joint courses, to be determined in cooperation with the Educational Council of the Diplomatic Academy, so that both services acquire substantive knowledge of the core issues of Greek (economic) foreign policy, given the now inseparable link between economic and political external relations. Further training for ECA officers should also be strengthened through cooperation with other actors, such as relevant ministries, universities, business associations and chambers of commerce. Such training should place particular emphasis on the development of digital skills (e.g. database analysis and the use of specialized software), and the acquisition of specialized knowledge relevant to the field.

2. Functioning and Adaptability:

2.1. The **institutions responsible for the design and implementation of economic diplomacy should develop close relations with local and sectoral chambers of commerce**, which possess in-depth knowledge of the opportunities and challenges within specific sectors of the economy. At the same time, cooperation between the central government and regional administrations should be strengthened, as the latter also contribute to the promotion of local products in international markets. It is undeniable that a bottom-up approach is necessary for the development of a holistic strategy aimed at cultivating economic and commercial relations with third countries.

2.2. It must be recognised that the implementation of a strategy also involves **private actors**, such as exporting companies, whose views and opinions should serve as an input into the strategic planning process. In this regard, the organisation and regular holding of meetings with all relevant stakeholders, through the establishment of a formal consultation mechanism and the creation of an appropriate institutional framework, will enable the government to better understand the needs of producers and businesses. Direct contact and interaction with the "users" of economic diplomacy are essential in the planning process, in order to fully understand the needs and challenges faced by Greek producers and entrepreneurs. Furthermore, the competent authorities should place greater emphasis on skills development and on training in the use of tools tailored to the needs of exporters.

I. **Lengthy and labyrinthine bureaucratic procedures must be replaced by modern digital platforms** capable of attracting investment and new talent. This requires a precise mapping of the obstacles faced by businesses, following an open dialogue among government institutions, regional administrations and the private sector.

2.3. The Offices of Economic and Commercial Affairs (ECA) around the world must take into account the size of the businesses they support. In particular, it should be recognised that **firms of different sizes have different needs**, and therefore a "one-size-fits-all" strategy cannot be applied.

i. **Small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs):** Greater emphasis should be placed on facilitating contact and cooperation with public authorities in the destination country, as these companies do not have the same level of access to government officials and business partners (B2B) as large corporations. They tend to rely on consulting firms, which significantly increases their costs. In practice, the participation of small firms in export activities is often constrained by internal limitations (e.g. insufficient financial resources) as well as external factors (e.g. international competition, tariffs, and non-tariff barriers).

ii. **Medium-sized enterprises:** Guidance should focus on identifying partners and suppliers, as well as on providing support for entry into foreign markets.

iii. **Large enterprises:** The primary objective of large companies is access to strategic information and meetings with government officials (B2G). ECA Offices can provide early-warning services, which are particularly important for corporate decision-making (e.g. regarding exchange-rate risks). Supporting large firms can also generate significant spillover benefits for their supply chains, which often include small and medium-sized enterprises.

2.4. **Better leveraging the Greek diaspora the Greek diaspora and Greek communities abroad should be a priority.** The presence and mobilisation of Greek communities in third markets can facilitate the identification of opportunities, provide guidance regarding bureaucratic procedures, and help identify the needs of consumers and businesses in local markets. At the same time, emphasis should be placed on transitional and emerging economies, such as those of Central Asia, Latin America, and India, by leveraging the limited but valuable Greek presence that can contribute to the development of new markets for high-quality Greek products.

3. Formulating a Strategy for Economic Diplomacy

3.1. **National Dimension:**

i. Actions aimed at promoting the country's economic and commercial interests abroad should be anchored in a coherent, long-term and realistic **National Economic Diplomacy Strategy.** Such a strategy should result from consultations among relevant public institutions, the private sector, as well as business associations and chambers of commerce. Its content should reflect the holistic nature of economic diplomacy, specifying objectives that cut across different ministries, while also being inclusive, so as to allow the direct exchange of views among relevant private and public stakeholders. At the same time, these objectives should be continuously evaluated, in order to ensure that resources are allocated to effective initiatives.

The key difference compared to the recently announced National Strategy for Extroversion lies in two points. First, the time horizon of this strategy should not be limited to 2030. Second, one of its central dimensions should address the geoeconomic implications and geopolitical conditions that not only shape a country's economic diplomacy in general, but may also potentially threaten national security interests. The consultations for designing this Strategy could take place within the framework of an interactive **Policy Lab**, which would serve as an incubator for new and innovative ideas aimed at structuring the future of Greek economic diplomacy and facilitating cooperation between the outward-oriented business and academic communities and the relevant public authorities.

An integral component of this strategy should be the promotion of a recognisable **brand name**. Projecting a coherent national image is possible only through the effective use of all modern communication tools and through the design of logos both for Greece and for emblematic national products, enabling them to be widely and easily recognised abroad. Particular emphasis should also be placed on the country's cultural heritage.

3.2. **European Dimension:**

i. Greece should strengthen the existing Export Credit Greece organisation while also promoting the establishment of a **European Export Credit Agency** and a comprehensive EU strategy for export financing, in order to reduce and manage the risks undertaken by exporters. Such an organisation would maximise the benefits of the EU's Global Gateway strategy. Despite the expected reservations from EU member states that already possess advanced export credit systems and mechanisms, Greece should invest diplomatic capital in promoting this initiative in order to benefit from the significant advantages of closer cooperation in the field of export credits. Greece's Presidency of the Council of the European Union during the second half of 2027 represents an opportunity for Greek foreign policy to advance such an initiative.

ii. With regard to European funding for projects and programmes in third countries, a positive **"pillar assessment"** constitutes a necessary condition for the selection of Greek organisations. More specifically, the European Commission cooperates with organisations and institutions from member states through indirect management of funds, following the submission of proposals or expressions of interest. A positive pillar assessment certifies that the participating organisations comply with standards of sound financial management and safeguard the financial interests of the Union. Although the evaluation process is complex and time-consuming, its successful completion may contribute both financially (through access to EU funding) and politically (through strengthened partnerships and closer engagement with international actors). In this context, an outward-looking Greek development bank should obtain such certification in order to be able to manage European funds and further promote the country's presence abroad.

iii. Support from the Greek side, particularly during Greece's Presidency of the Council of the EU in 2027, for the completion of the Single Market, as emphasised in the Draghi and Letta reports, could further promote Greek economic interests. For example, the systematic reduction of barriers restricting the free movement of goods, services, capital and people within the Union strengthens the competitiveness of small and medium-sized enterprises, enabling them to enter a wider range of markets.

iv. At the same time, a more active policy aimed at increasing the number of Greek seconded national experts in the European Commission's Directorates-General or in European agencies dealing with issues related to economic diplomacy (e.g. DG TAXUD) would indirectly strengthen Greek influence in Brussels. Following the same logic, Greek foreign policy could seek to host key European agencies or services. For example, Greece could pursue more actively the hosting of the new European Customs Authority. Similarly, the country could bid to host supporting or specialised structures in priority areas such as new technologies, artificial intelligence and big data processing.

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Appendix: Illustrative List of Good Practices

Country	Type of Economic Diplomacy	Description
Australia	Education & Tourism Diplomacy	Promotion of Australia as a destination for study and leisure. Provision of scholarships and development of university partnerships. Higher education constitutes a major export sector.
Vietnam	Bamboo Diplomacy	Implementation of the "bamboo diplomacy" strategy focusing on exports, investment, tourism and technological development. Mobilisation of embassies and local authorities in more than 700 initiatives. Seventeen free trade agreements have been signed. Technological diplomacy is further strengthened through partnerships with leading companies such as Apple, Intel, Google, NVIDIA, Samsung, LG, Siemens and others.
Brazil	Multilateral Diplomacy through BRICS	Participation in development banks (e.g. the NDB), with the aim of redistributing global economic influence and securing access to strategic financing and infrastructure projects.
France	«Team France Export»	A unified initiative bringing together the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, the Ministry of Trade, Bpifrance, and regional authorities. Digital platforms offering guidance for export activities and support for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs).
Germany	"Mittelstand Global" for SMEs	Support for small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) to export through state instruments (e.g. Hermes Export Credit). Sector-specific trade missions. Germany remains a leading exporting power worldwide.
UAE	Free Economic Zones Diplomacy	Creation of zones such as Jebel Ali offering tax incentives. Strategic use of the UAE's geographic location as a transit hub. The combination of logistics, investment, and a favourable business environment has made Dubai a global centre for trade and services.
Spain	«Brand Spain»	Development of a unified branding strategy for Spain, focusing on the promotion of tourism and culture. Emphasis on sustainable development and "green" policies as instruments for enhancing the country's international image.
Canada	«Global Affairs Canada» – Team Canada Missions	Development of a global network of trade commissioners in more than 160 locations. Connecting innovative Canadian businesses with international markets. Promotion of Canadian technology and strengthening the international outreach of the Canadian business ecosystem.

Kenya	Agri-Diplomacy & Technology	Leveraging digital logistics platforms to boost exports (e.g. fresh flowers). Development of a national identity for agricultural products, such as "Kenya Coffee." Kenya ranks among the leading exporters of fresh flowers to the EU.
China	Diplomacy through the "Belt and Road Initiative"	Infrastructure investments in developing countries financed by state-owned banks. Strengthening strong bilateral relations, particularly with countries in Africa and Central Asia. The BRI constitutes a key vehicle for economic and geopolitical influence.
South Korea	Integrated Export Policy Framework - KOTRA	Promotion of exports and investment through the Korea Trade-Investment Promotion Agency (KOTRA). An assertive branding strategy with emphasis on the "Korea Premium" brand and high-technology sectors (electronics, K-beauty, K-pop).
Netherlands	Sustainable Economic Diplomacy	Implementation of the Dutch Good Growth Fund to support investments in developing countries based on sustainable standards. Development of a unified branding strategy ("Holland Branding") in sectors such as agricultural technology, water management, and logistics. Establishment of Innovation Centres within embassies to connect startups with international markets.
Sweden	Nation Branding	A national strategy of international promotion aimed at establishing Sweden's image as a country of innovation, sustainability, political stability, and a high quality of life.
Turkey	Trade and Development Cooperation Diplomacy	Active promotion of bilateral trade agreements, particularly with countries in Africa and Central Asia. Combination of trade, construction projects, and cultural influence (soft power). Significant increase in exports by Turkish companies and in infrastructure projects.
Finland	Integrated Economic Diplomacy through "Team Finland	The Ministry of Foreign Affairs and Finnish embassies promote the internationalization of Finnish businesses, the removal of trade barriers, and the attraction of foreign investment. Use of bilateral, European, and multilateral mechanisms through the EU and the WTO. Cooperation with Invest in Finland to attract targeted investments.
Chile	Agricultural Products Diplomacy	Targeted promotion of high-quality agricultural products, such as wine and fruit, in specialised markets. Active diplomatic efforts to remove tariffs and non-tariff barriers. Chile is a global leader in exports of off-season fruit.